

prehensile
upper lip

Giraffe

Giraffa camelopardalis

Giraffes are the world's tallest living animals, with adult males reaching 16–20 ft (5–6 m) and adult females growing to 15–16 ft (4.5–5 m). Even the calves are 5–6 ft (1.5–1.8 m) tall at birth. Much of this height comes from the giraffe's massively elongated neck and legs. It has thick blood vessels, high blood pressure, and a powerful heart to pump blood all the way to its brain.

Despite their size, giraffes are threatened by predators. A pride of lions can bring down an adult, and young calves are vulnerable to hyenas and leopards. If alarmed, giraffes can gallop at speeds of up to 35 mph (55 km/h).

Unique markings

The Masai giraffe (*G. c. tippelskirchi*) is one of nine subspecies, each of which has a different pattern of red-brown or almost black markings, with straight or fuzzy edges, on a white or yellow background. It lives in small herds in the Serengeti savanna and open woodland, and can browse leaves from trees that are out of reach of antelopes and other browsers. Giraffes have a prehensile upper lip and an extremely long, tough, and mobile tongue, which enables them to strip leaves from thorny acacia trees with ease.

Both sexes have a pair of blunt, skin-covered horns, called ossicones, which are larger in males. The females mate with the dominant bull in their home range, giving birth to a single calf after 16 months, usually in the dry season. She will have weaned the calf by the time it is 13 months old.



△ RITUALIZED "NECKING"

Male giraffes reach sexual maturity at three to four years. To establish dominance, rivals engage in a ritual battle that involves slamming their necks against each other.

distinctive skin pattern
of Masai giraffe

long black
tail tuft for
whisking
away flies

markings fade
toward feet

- ↔ 12½–15½ ft (3.8–4.7 m)
- 🏠 Up to 2.1 tons (1.9 metric tons)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Tree leaves
- 🏠 🌿



Africa

▷ STANDING TALL

As well as their great height, giraffes are distinguished by their large eyes and ears, short body, and a back that slopes steeply from shoulder to rump.